

Orthodox Christian teaching about baptism, in our age when baptism is misunderstood, maligned, omitted, and performed haphazardly and wrongly.

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This wordy title, above, describes the subject of this pastoral letter. This short letter cannot explain everything, and I invite anyone who has any questions to talk to me or Father Nicholas about this.

We live in an age...

We live in an age when people are very confused about where the church is and where it isn't.

We live in an age when priests and even bishops of the Orthodox Church say things that are outrageous, and even heretical.

We live in an age when, even in the Orthodox Church, people are trying to be "nice", and not offend people that are not in the church.

We live in an age when the practice of baptism for converts is being ignored and even categorically refused, often because of false teaching.

We live in an age when the practice of baptism ignores the age-old three immersions in favor of a practice that looks indistinguishable from that of the heretics.

We live in an age when the age-old practice of the church receiving converts is being discarded in favor of a new theology championed by the Latins and certain of the Orthodox, including even the Ecumenical Patriarch, who tried to ram this theology into the Orthodox Church in the failed counsel of Crete.

We live in an age when false practices and teaching are being labeled as "economia¹," and traditional practices and teachings are being slandered as "fundamentalist" and even as heresy.

The church is the pillar and ground of truth, and its pillars are being attacked.

One of the most important roles of an Orthodox Christian priest is to maintain “What has been believed everywhere, always, and by all” (Commonitorium by Vincent of Lérins, about 434). We must always be vigilant not to allow any slippage in our dogmatic theology and moral and liturgical practices. They are all intertwined. If there is poor dogmatic theology, this will lead to immorality, and liturgical practices will suffer. Where there is immorality, theology becomes heretical, and liturgical practices degrade. If there are poor liturgical practices, especially if they are very similar to those of the heretics, inevitably, dogmatic theology and

morality will slip. We are in an age when all three of these pillars upon which the truth of the church is fixed are being attacked, even within the Orthodox Church.

I want to stress to you that the church is a pillar and ground of truth, and this truth is expressed in what we believe, how we act, and how we pray. If any one of these three things is tainted, everything else will become tainted. We are especially in an age now when baptism is a linchpin by which our dogma, morality, and liturgical practices are being degraded.

True and False teaching and practices regarding baptism.

The consistent teaching of the Russian Orthodox Church Outside of Russia is that baptism is a sacrament of the Church, whereby a person is joined to the Church. Therefore, baptism cannot be received outside the boundaries of the (Orthodox) Church.

Anyone outside of the Orthodox Church who has something that appears to be baptism has received an empty form of baptism that does not join a person to the church. One who is joined to the Church is, by default, received through baptism in the Orthodox church.

This has been our practice in our parish from the beginning. Except by extreme economy (once that I remember, a person who was sick and had dementia was chrismated, with the blessing of Archbishop Peter of blessed memory), we have never received any

convert, no matter what their background, by anything other than the catechumen prayers with the four exorcisms, anointing with the oil of gladness, baptism, and chrismation.

The Russian Orthodox Church has had historically sometimes had a practice of receiving converts from certain other religions through chrismation, based on how consistent their faith in the Trinity is with ours and the extent to which they have preserved the form of baptism. We understand this to be an act of “economy” whereby the Church, through her bishops, can diverge from the ideal for practical and pastoral reasons. This reception is no less real than a reception through baptism.

When chrismation is used to receive that a person who had a previous form of baptism that is deemed to

be acceptable, our clear teaching is that the empty form of baptism is filled with grace by the act of chrismation. We never say that that person was previously “baptized,” and that is why they are chrismated. We say that they received an empty form of baptism which did not bring them into the church, but was acceptable according to our standards and according to economy, the bishop has allowed for chrismation without baptism, which fills the empty form of baptism, and brings a person fully into the Orthodox Church, just as if they had been baptized in the Orthodox church, and then chrismated.

It is critical to understand that there is no teaching in the church that mandates chrismation without baptism for anyone who comes from a non-orthodox Christian confession. It may be possible to receive such a person by chrismation, but great harm is done to a person if they are refused baptism or if they are told that their apparent “baptism” already was “valid” and that, since a second baptism is forbidden by the Nicene creed, they cannot be baptized. If a person thinks that their previous form of baptism was “valid” what else do they think was valid in their previous practice and belief?

Even more harm is done to them when, because they are refused baptism, they are taught that baptizing them would be putting Christ on the cross again, and is therefore, a great sin.

And again, more harm is done when the liturgical practices become so slipshod that the person who is chrismated does not receive catechumen prayers with exorcisms, catechesis, anointing with the oil of gladness, or chrismation on all of the parts of the body that are prescribed in our service books.

We live in a time of the “Wild West” when any or all of these things, which are departures from our tradition, are “normal.” To be sure, there are priests who receive via chrismation, usually because their bishop mandates it, who otherwise follow all of the traditions, with the full catechumen prayers with exorcisms, full catechesis, the proper teaching about the form of baptism that they previously received, chrismation on all the parts of the body that are mandated by our services, and in many cases renunciation of former errors. These priests are increasingly rare.

Since, in our day, baptism is being attacked by false teaching and false practices, it is critically important to receive converts by baptism. That is what our church has been teaching and doing for a long time.

A false teaching has arisen in recent decades that baptism acts independently of the Church – that anybody who is baptized with water in the name of the Trinity, by anybody, or even sometimes by some other means and words, is thereby part of the Church, whether they or anybody in the Church knows it or not. On this basis, they say that those who receive baptism outside the Church can only be received into the Church through Chrismation or Confession. This is a new teaching that is not consistent with the Church’s historical teaching. The official documents of the Moscow Patriarchate, for instance, state that while the Church receives converts through a variety of means, recognizing that grace is not entirely absent from groups who have separated from the Church, it is not thus making any statement about the degree to which grace may or may not be active in any particular group, considering this a mystery of God’s Providence.

The reasons for doing baptism are pastoral and theological, and those reasons are being ignored by

many people, but that is the sin of the priest and the bishop and not of the person being received unless the

person being received bullies the priest into the method of reception that they prefer.



Baptism by pouring in an Orthodox Church. Not different in appearance to the Latin Baptism.

Righting wrongs.

A priest can sin and do things for the wrong reasons and even with the wrong theology and practice, and, on a practical level, that sin can harm the person who's being taught and received wrongly, but, if the priest is serving under a canonical Bishop, we do not say that his sacrament is not effectual. Certainly, his pastoral teaching may not be effectual, and it may be very harmful, but we do not say that the formal sacrament is not valid.

This is the baseline for our belief and practice regarding all methods of reception by a canonical Orthodox priest, but unfortunately, methods of reception vary so wildly that it appears that, contrary to the prophet, there are continually new things under the sun. And one wonders, how bad can a method of reception be and still give grace?

By grace, I do not mean just that, because of grace, a person has become an Orthodox Christian. Grace is the visitation of God with the soul in a salvific way. We

don't stand on formality regarding grace. Everything is important. We should follow the church traditions, we should teach correctly, and we should baptize correctly.

When a priest receives a person in the Orthodox Church, it is so that they can be transformed in every way. If there is incorrect doctrine regarding a person's method of reception, they are formally received into the church, but their heart may not have completely changed regarding their former errors. And perhaps their former way of life included occult practices and demonic activity. Do we really want to receive such people without saying exorcisms over them, these exorcisms that have been prescribed by the church for the reception of converts for millennia?

Certainly, there are many people who have been chrismated under false pretenses, and we do not baptize them, except under exceptional circumstances where substantial spiritual harm has occurred, but all

such people have suffered spiritually, and sometimes they have suffered greatly. And then there are sometimes bizarre things done, and one wonders what to do.

The issue is not whether or not Chrismation can bring a person into the church. It is that there is a false theology that is supporting the reason for it. The new theology, which is Latin in origin and which took over a hundred years to bring into their teaching and practice, is that there is valid baptism everywhere, and we cannot repeat baptism. Some even go so far as to state in a way that appears to me to be blasphemy, that someone who supposedly rebaptizes a convert who has only had the form of baptism is putting Christ back on the cross. I myself have had this slander levied at me. That is not the Christian teaching.

Have you heard about the broken window doctrine? It was employed to great effect to make New York City safe many years ago. The idea is that a broken window in a house will lead to the house being vandalized. Therefore, little things matter. It matters how we receive a person; it matters how the rite of baptism is administered; it matters whether or not we say all of the exorcism prayers, etc. etc. With false theology comes false practice, and with false practice comes false theology and with false practice and false theology comes bad morality. It's a truth that repeats itself over and over and over again.

There are people who have come to me in great distress because of the method of their reception, and asked for baptism. With some, after significant investigation, and because of their individual circumstances, I asked and received Archbishop Peter's blessing to baptize them. Others I have turned down. Over the years, I have talked many people out of seeking baptism when they had already been received by chrismation. I will not baptize a person who desires

it after their reception because of psychological reasons. I evaluated the situation, and if there was significant spiritual harm done, then I went and talked to my Bishop.

I am a pastor and I do pastoral things, and a person cannot understand the nature of taking care of people until they do it. Unfortunately, in our modern age, there are many who have absolutely no pastoral experience, but have read a few books, and posted on the Internet. Our theology and practice must be pastoral. Otherwise, there is only "knowledge that puffs up."

When I encounter people that are really in distress and the distress is:

because of the false things they were taught about baptism

or that they were absolutely categorically refused baptism when they begged for it,

or they were not given any catechumen prayers or exorcisms or any catechism,

and they have suffered spiritual harm, then as a pastor, I must act.

This is an exceptional pastoral action, and I believe I have done it 4 times, each time with the blessing of Archbishop Peter, of blessed memory.

By the way, decisions like the ones above are one of the great reasons why everybody should pray for their pastor with a prostration every day. In our parish, you should do two prostrations, one for me, and one for Fr Nicholas. None of this pastoral work is easy, and all of it is hard, and all of it is being done by a man with clay feet.

The practice that we have had from the beginning of our parish life of baptizing all converts is routinely slandered in the Orthodox world and outside of it. I actually had a priest, who theoretically should

understand these things, tell me that I was putting Christ on the cross again by baptizing converts who had previously some form of baptism, which he considers to be true baptism. Another theologically illiterate slander is that we are violating the Symbol of Faith since it says that we believe in one baptism. Of course, we believe in one baptism! We believe that the church can baptize and that once the church baptizes, it is never repeated.

The form of baptism that the church officially accepts and allows for chrismation is baptism in the name of the Holy Trinity with three immersions. This

allowance is only by economy that is by the discretion of the bishop and priest, and is never obligatory. That form is rarely observed.

Today, even in the Orthodox Church, that form often is not observed because baptism via pouring, which looks identical to the way the Latins generally do it, or by partial immersion, and then pouring or splashing is becoming commonplace.

We live in an age of theological, practical, and pedagogical chaos. I am doing what I can, and my bishops are doing what they can to stem the tide of this torrent of false teaching and false practice.

Archpriest Seraphim Holland

Sunday of the Prodigal Son, Feb 3/16 2025

<http://www.orthodox.net/articles/orthodox-christian-teaching-about-baptism-in-our-age.docx>

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¹ The practice of economy and is basically when there is a deviation from the strict rule (akrivia) because of pastoral need. It is never mandated. We should always do the mandated rules and practices of the Orthodox Church, except when it is necessary because of pastoral care to deviate from them. In small matters, such as fasting rules, a priest fully able to give economy to someone and moderate their fasting regimen. In cases such as reception of converts by any method other than baptism and chrismation, only the bishop has the authority to apply economia. Economia is always an exception, based on specific circumstances. When it becomes the rule, then everything is turned on its head. This is what we are experiencing in our day, when a method of reception that can be exercised by economy is made into the rule of reception.